

sumption of digital content. According to industry estimates, e-books generate five per cent of overall book sales in the country.

Although e-books are yet to create a firmer space in the publishing market, these are relatively witnessing growth. On an optimistic note, major publishers and business owners have indicated that sale of e-books would contribute between fifteen and twenty per cent of their total revenue over the next five years.

Popularity of e-books in India

There are various reasons why e-books are getting popular in India. First, technology has advanced significantly for comfortable reading of e-books. Coupled with that, digital platforms offer easy accessibility, convenience and affordability. This strikes the right chord with tech-savvy young readers who are ready to embrace the new trend of digitised reading.

Mostly, students and busy professionals use digitised formats as they find it handier and can access many books free of cost. The biggest attraction of e-books is that these are available online at much lower prices, in comparison with brick-and-mortar-book stores. Besides, what contributes more to the popularity of e-books is the availability of free online reading platforms, such as Google Books, Internet Archive, Open Library, Scribd, Bookish, Wattpad, etc.

There are also many other online platforms where readers can share and upload their written work alongside other published writers. This generates interest and enthusiasm, as the writers get to see their view numbers and reviews by readers.

Now, e-books are not restricted to English language alone. To further integrate regional language-based work with the mainstream, Amazon has launched e-books in five regional languages, namely, Hindi, Tamil, Marathi, Gujarati and Malayalam. Eighty per cent growth in sales has been reported after the addition of these domestic languages.

Pros of e-books

e-Books open up many new possibilities for dissemination. These give the opportunity for wider global reach and eliminate the problem of inaccessibility because of distance. Their portability enables readers to take hundreds of books anywhere they go. All e-books are stored in the reader's online personal account.

e-Books come with search option, where readers can easily look up any information, instead of wasting time turning page after page. These also have the option to bookmark a page. Most of the content in e-books is cloud-based, meaning, writers can add the latest information anytime, simultaneously providing readers with updated content. The process avoids investment on reprinting costs and also the time involved to a great extent.

Further, some e-books are equipped with interactive elements, which can enhance the reading experience and make it more engaging. These contain video, audio and animations that are ideal for children and visually-impaired people. And, external links/hyperlinks can also be integrated that help gather extra information.

Unlike tradition publishing, the whole procedure of e-book publishing is easy, fast and less time-consuming. In printed book publishing, the author has to go through many challenges to get the right agent and publishing deal. **Today, Amazon's Kindle Direct Publishing has made things much easier. The writer can directly put his or her book for sale online within days of its publishing.**

Cons of e-books

e-Books come with some unfavourable factors, too. If the e-book reader is not charged or the battery is out of order, the e-book cannot be accessed or read. This creates a lot of inconvenience if there is no nearby power source.

Compatibility of software with e-book devices is important. Otherwise, files cannot be downloaded easily.

Another main flip side of e-books is the notifications that pop up every now and then on the device. This creates distraction that can take the reader away from an immersive reading. This happens mostly when reading on a phone or tablet. The effort to delete or dismiss these notifications fails to optimise the reading experience.

e-Books do not come with a defined lifetime. New technologies keep emerging in the market. Therefore software programs need to be upgraded in tune with the technology being used. This increases the risk of losing saved files/books and formatting of documents.

Lastly, e-books can pose a slew of health risks. Reading tablets and backlit e-readers for night-time reading can cause sleep deficiency, eyestrain and/or damage health.

The e-book market in India

e-Books are still a growing segment in India's publishing industry. These will take time to outstrip and dominate the Indian book market. However, considering the increasing use of technology, in addition to easy reach, e-books are likely to capture a bigger slice in the e-book market soon.

Notably, technological innovations play a significant role in fuelling the growth of the industry. Now, design of e-books keeps upgrading with more sophistication, replicating the look and feel of physical books. Fonts can be adjusted, screens can be backlit and users can turn the pages digitally to make the reading experience more comfortable.

Such technical advances are encouraging readers to explore the e-reading space, which, in turn, is impacting the market in a positive way. The interesting news is that, now more Indian book publishers and book retailers are trying to bring the diverse literary work of regional languages into digital formats. Such efforts will help expand and penetrate the e-book market even deeper, and boost the Indian market. **EFY**